

■ STUDY BEES ■

ONE ACT PLAY

Fourteen

by

Alice Gerstenberg

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About the Play

Fourteen is a short comic one-act play by the American playwright Alice Gerstenberg. It is a satire of upper-class social life, poking fun at the anxious vanity of hostesses who judge a dinner party's success purely by the number and status of guests who attend. The entire play unfolds in a single room, in real time, and depends almost entirely on one side of a series of telephone conversations, a technique that creates humour and suspense as the audience must guess what is being said on the other end of the line.

The play belongs to the genre of the comedy of manners, using light humour to expose the shallowness and pretension that can lie beneath polished social behaviour.

Characters

Protagonist

Mrs. Pringle — A fashionable society hostess preparing an important dinner party for fourteen guests. She is vain, image-conscious and desperate to appear socially successful, and the play follows her mounting panic as her carefully planned party begins to fall apart.

Antagonistic Force

There is no single human villain in the play; instead, the antagonist is circumstance itself — a string of last-minute phone calls in which invited guests cancel one after another. This impersonal, almost comic 'antagonist' steadily strips away Mrs. Pringle's plans and exposes her vanity and desperation to save appearances.

Other Characters

- **Mary (the maid/servant)** — Assists Mrs. Pringle and reports on preparations, occasionally reacting to her mistress's growing distress.
- **The Unseen Callers** — The invited guests and their spouses, heard only through Mrs. Pringle's side of the telephone conversation, each offering a different excuse for cancelling.

Summary

Mrs. Pringle is putting the finishing touches on an elaborate dinner party for fourteen guests, proud of the careful seating arrangement and the impressive guest list she has assembled to raise her social standing. The telephone begins to ring, and one by one, guests call to cancel — a sudden illness, a prior commitment, a family emergency — each excuse chipping away at her perfect number of fourteen.

As the calls continue, Mrs. Pringle grows increasingly anxious, scrambling to invite replacement guests at the last minute so that the table will not look empty and her reputation will not suffer. Her conversation is full of forced politeness to the callers and barely hidden frustration and panic once she hangs up. Despite her frantic efforts, the cancellations keep coming faster than she can replace them.

By the end of the play, nearly all the original guests have dropped out, and Mrs. Pringle is left with far fewer people than she planned — sometimes read as ending with almost no guests at all. Her obsession with appearances and status is left comically and pitifully exposed, as the grand party she imagined collapses into

near-emptiness.

Plot Structure

Exposition

The play opens with Mrs. Pringle confidently reviewing her preparations for a dinner party of fourteen carefully chosen guests, establishing her pride in her social planning.

Inciting Incident

The telephone rings with the first regret — a guest cancelling — puncturing Mrs. Pringle's confidence and starting her scramble to manage the situation.

Rising Action

A rapid sequence of phone calls brings more cancellations, each with its own excuse; Mrs. Pringle reacts with growing anxiety, making hurried calls to find replacement guests and adjusting her seating plans again and again.

Climax

The tension peaks as cancellations arrive faster than Mrs. Pringle can find substitutes, and she realises she may not be able to save the dinner party's appearance of success at all.

Anticlimax

Instead of a dramatic confrontation, the crisis resolves through the ordinary, faintly absurd process of more phone calls — undercutting the seriousness Mrs. Pringle has invested in the situation and highlighting the play's comic tone.

Falling Action

With most of her guest list gone, Mrs. Pringle must reconcile herself to a drastically reduced party, her earlier boasts and careful arrangements now meaningless.

Denouement and Resolution

The play closes on Mrs. Pringle's forced composure in the face of near-total failure, the comic gap between her social ambitions and the reality of her nearly empty table delivering the play's final satirical point.

Themes

- **Social Pretension and Vanity:** Mrs. Pringle's dinner party is less about hospitality than about status, and her distress reveals how much value she places on appearances.
- **Hypocrisy in Social Life:** the polite, sympathetic tone Mrs. Pringle uses on the phone contrasts sharply with her private irritation, exposing the gap between social manners and true feeling.
- **The Absurdity of Status-Seeking:** the play gently mocks a society in which a person's worth seems to be measured by the guest list at their dinner table.
- **Isolation Behind a Social Mask:** despite being surrounded by 'friends,' Mrs. Pringle is shown to be genuinely alone once the social performance collapses.

Literary Devices

- **One-Sided Dialogue (Telephone Technique):** the audience hears only Mrs. Pringle's side of each call, using implication and reaction to convey what unseen characters are saying — a hallmark device of the play.
- **Dramatic Irony:** the audience senses the party's collapse building long before Mrs. Pringle fully admits it to herself.
- **Satire:** the play uses gentle mockery to criticise class-conscious, appearance-obsessed social behaviour.
- **Comic Repetition:** the repeated pattern of phone calls and cancellations builds rhythm and humour as the situation escalates.
- **Unity of Time and Place:** the entire action unfolds in one room in real time, intensifying the sense of mounting pressure on Mrs. Pringle.

SLO-Based Questions & Answers

Q: Who wrote the one-act play Fourteen?

Ans: Alice Gerstenberg.

Q: What kind of event is Mrs. Pringle preparing for at the start of the play?

Ans: A dinner party for fourteen carefully chosen, socially important guests.

Q: What literary technique does the play rely on to tell most of its story?

Ans: A series of telephone calls in which the audience hears only Mrs. Pringle's side of the conversation.

Q: What starts happening soon after the play begins?

Ans: Invited guests begin phoning in to cancel their attendance, one after another, each with a different excuse.

Q: How does Mrs. Pringle react to the cancellations?

Ans: With growing anxiety and panic, frantically calling other people to find last-minute replacement guests.

Q: What does Mrs. Pringle's behaviour on the phone reveal about her character?

Ans: It reveals her vanity and obsession with social appearances — she stays outwardly polite to callers while privately growing desperate.

Q: What is the climax of the play?

Ans: The point at which cancellations are arriving faster than Mrs. Pringle can replace them, threatening to ruin her party entirely.

Q: How does the play's tone stay comic even at its most tense moment?

Ans: Through the absurdity and repetition of the phone calls, which keep the crisis lighthearted rather than genuinely alarming.

Q: How does the play end?

Ans: With Mrs. Pringle's grand dinner party reduced to only a handful of guests, exposing the gap between her social ambitions and reality.

Q: What is the main theme of Fourteen?

Ans: The vanity and hypocrisy of social status-seeking, and the absurdity of judging self-worth by appearances.

Q: Why can the play be called a 'comedy of manners'?

Ans: Because it uses humour to critique the polished but shallow behaviour of upper-class social life.

Q: Who is the central character (protagonist) of the play?

Ans: Mrs. Pringle, the anxious society hostess.

Q: Is there a traditional human antagonist in the play?

Ans: No — the 'antagonist' is the situation itself: the string of cancellations that undoes Mrs. Pringle's plans.

Q: What role does Mary play in the story?

Ans: She is Mrs. Pringle's maid, assisting with preparations and present as a quiet witness to her mistress's mounting distress.

Q: What message does the play convey about social image?

Ans: That an obsessive focus on appearances and status can leave a person anxious, isolated, and ultimately exposed as insincere.